National interest has operational costs and making those decisions is often the most difficult responsibility of leadership.

The Pandavas are an excellent example of integration. Born of different mothers and each with a complex paternal origin, they function very well as a team overcoming internal tensions. They have complementary skill sets that make the combination particularly effective. As a model, they should inspire greater deliberation on the difficulties of working together efficiently. India has more than its fair share of this problem because we are blessed with both social pluralism and extreme individualism. Overlaid with the reality that there has been limited administrative reform, the need for greater integration is really very strong. Jointness, coordination and sharing are connected challenges of all large organizations. They grapple with set habits, vested interest and distinct identities. Agreeing at the headlines level rarely leads automatically to it working out operationally. Some of it may be conscious, but history and experience do pull in the opposite direction. Indeed, other than building better capabilities, breaking silos is as close as one can come to a silver bullet in the field of policy implementation.

If we in India have acquired a reputation for operating with sub-optimal coordination, it is because our history is replete with examples that came at great cost. Individualism could be aggravated by a possessiveness which has been enhanced by shortages. Bureaucratism has also been entrenched in our society. What perhaps adds to all of this is a focus on process rather than concern over outcomes. The lack of integration comes in different forms, but it is only by attacking them in all their manifestations that Indian foreign policy can really change for the better.

The Mahabharata is a saga of approaches and choices whose cumulative impact propels the polity in a certain direction. Each of them holds some lesson for the current times. The Kauravas, most notably, push competition to its extreme limits, creating a backlash that even justifies the emulation of their abominable tactics. The Pandavas, in contrast, build brand and display strategic patience. As a result, they are able to defeat a superior adversary, in part by the use of asymmetric tactics. Karna represents alliance discipline at its best, highlighting the impact of polarization. Bheeshma and Drona